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A

s Simon Harmer continued to spin his web around the Indian batters in Guwahati during the second Test, broadcasters kept highlighting how much slower the South African spinners were operating compared to their Indian counterparts.

A few minutes after he closed off the game and the series with a six-wicket haul, Harmer revealed that slowing down was a deliberate ploy, tailored to the red-soil pitch in Guwahati.

"Coming here, we spoke about it and with the red soil pitch being a bouncer, quicker turn sort of wicket, we felt that the slower pace would be better," said Harmer at the post-match press conference.

It was also, in effect, an inadvertent double bluff.

In the Kolkata Test, played on a diabolically unpredictable surface, Harmer and Co. were quicker

through the air. It was a trick lifted directly from the Indian spin playbook, and it delivered spectacular results. Harmer, Keshav Maharaj and Aiden Markram combined for seven of the nine wickets to fall in India's doomed 124-run chase.

"If you look at the Indian finger spinners, they're extremely accurate. On surfaces that assist spin, it becomes very difficult because at that pace, you force a batter to commit very early. Slower pace allows the batter to adjust once the ball is bounced," explains Harmer.

As it turned out, the Indian tweakers amped up their speed in Guwahati, only to discover that the South Africans had gone the other way.

"I don't know if they got caught up in what happened in the first Test

Lost assurance: A wicket that felt inevitable. K.L. Rahul undone as India's long-held certainties against spin continued to slip. RITU RAJ KONWAR

